

MEMORANDUM

TO: Joint Senior Enlisted Leaders and Officer in Charge (OIC)

FROM: Edward A. Schave

DATE: May 26, 2026

SUBJECT: Proposal to Streamline and Standardize Requirement Trackers

Summary of the Problem

In our joint-service office, one of the most significant challenges we currently face is the massive proliferation of independent requirement trackers. Because each military branch brings its own distinct reporting needs and metrics, we have inadvertently created multiple shared trackers that revolve around the same core information but do not communicate with one another. None of these trackers update automatically. As a result, personnel spend **an estimated 8–12 hours per week** manually cross-referencing older spreadsheets to ensure the newer ones contain accurate data. This repetitive effort occurs **daily**, especially during reporting cycles, and diverts time away from mission-support tasks. A single, all-encompassing master tracker is not a realistic alternative, as it would become too dense and complex for anyone outside our immediate office to interpret.

Project Description

This project proposes a systematic streamlining of our current data management processes to eliminate redundant administrative burdens. Rather than attempting to force all branches into a single, massive spreadsheet, which would only create confusion, we will reduce duplicate trackers, standardize core data fields across all services, and assign clear, individual ownership for specific updates. By establishing a unified baseline for how data is entered and shared, we will create a leaner, more efficient tracking ecosystem. This approach prevents our team from doing the same work multiple times and ensures that all localized trackers pull from standardized, reliable data definitions. Ultimately, this will give everyone more time to focus on actual mission-support tasks rather than juggling multiple spreadsheets.

Rationale and Significance

Maintaining multiple, disconnected tracking systems essentially creates "data silos" within our office. These silos leave our team working with fragmented and inconsistent data, which degrades data quality and generates severe operational inefficiencies through duplicated workflows (**Aquino et al., n.d.**). When decision-makers, such as yourselves,

need to review readiness or workflow metrics, relying on siloed data can lead to a delayed or incomplete operational picture.

Furthermore, when team members are forced to perform repetitive, manual data entry across several spreadsheets, the risk of human error increases exponentially. These seemingly minor data entry errors are a hidden epidemic that can lead to significant operational bottlenecks, requiring countless hours to reconcile conflicting numbers (OpsAnalitica, 2025). This constant need for manual correction is a massive drain on overall productivity and morale.

By standardizing our data fields and streamlining the existing trackers, we can directly combat these inefficiencies. Implementing data standardization simplifies reporting and reduces manual manipulation efforts, laying a trusted foundation for effective decision-making (Profisee, n.d.). When data formats and structures are consistent across the different service branches, we eliminate redundancies. This optimized workflow will return valuable time to our personnel, ensuring that requirements are managed accurately and efficiently without the need for constant, repetitive data entry.

Plan of Work/Tasks

The implementation of this project will be conducted in a phased approach over eight weeks to ensure minimal disruption to ongoing operations:

1. Needs Assessment & Audit (Weeks 1-2): Review all existing trackers currently in use across the joint-service office to identify overlaps, redundant data points, and branch-specific requirements.
2. Standardization of Fields (Week 3): Collaborate with branch representatives to define a standardized set of core data fields (e.g., naming conventions, date formats, status codes) that successfully meet all service requirements.
3. Consolidation & Redesign (Weeks 4-5): Reduce the total number of trackers by archiving duplicates and formatting the remaining active spreadsheets to utilize the newly established standardized data fields.
4. Assignment of Ownership (Week 6): Establish a clear workflow matrix that assigns specific individuals or desks as the sole owners responsible for updating designated data sets. This ensures accountability and eliminates duplicate entry.
5. Training and Rollout (Weeks 7-8): Conduct brief, targeted training sessions for all office personnel on the new trackers, workflow rules, and standardized data entry procedures before officially retiring the old trackers.

6. Budget: Because this project utilizes existing office software, there are no capital expenditures or software procurement costs. The budget exclusively reflects the estimated internal cost of reallocated labor (working man-hours) required to complete the project phases.
7. The estimates below are calculated using an assumed average burdened labor rate of \$45/hour for participating personnel:

Project Phase / Activity	Estimated Man-Hours	Estimated Labor Cost
Needs Assessment & Audit: Reviewing existing trackers across all branches.	20 Hours	\$ 900
Data Field Standardization: Workshops with branch representatives to define core data.	12 Hours	\$ 540
Consolidation & Redesign: Archiving duplicates and formatting the new master templates.	16 Hours	\$ 720
Training & Rollout: Developing materials and conducting brief team training sessions.	8 Hours	\$ 360
GRAND TOTAL	56 Hours	\$ 2,520

Note: This represents an upfront investment of 56 man-hours. However, eliminating redundant data entry across multiple trackers is projected to save the team at least 10 man-hours per week, meaning this project will achieve a positive return on invested time within six weeks of implementation.

Conclusion

Our joint-service office currently loses critical man-hours to the redundant, manual updating of disparate requirement trackers. By streamlining our spreadsheets, standardizing our data fields, and assigning clear update ownership, we can break down internal data silos and drastically improve workflow efficiency. This project will take approximately eight weeks to implement, requiring an internal labor investment of roughly 56 man-hours (valued at approximately \$2,520). Ultimately, this initial investment of time will pay for itself rapidly, allowing our team to stop juggling spreadsheets and dedicate significantly more time to our primary mission-support objectives while providing leadership with cleaner, more reliable data.

References

Aquino, J., Badman, A., & Kosinski, M. (n.d.). *What are data silos?* IBM. Retrieved May 27, 2026, <https://www.ibm.com/think/topics/data-silos>

OpsAnalitica. (2025, October 8). *The cost of data entry errors: How they hurt your profits and productivity*. OpsAnalitica. <https://www.opsanalitica.com/blog/the-cost-of-data-entry-errors-how-they-hurt-your-profits-and-productivity>

Profisee. (n.d.). *What is data standardization and why it matters*. Profisee. Retrieved May 27, 2026, from <https://profisee.com/blog/what-is-data-standardization/>

Note on AI Usage:

Gemini Enterprise was utilized to check the flow and formatting of this project proposal against the specific assignment requirements. All core concepts, research, and final writing remain my original work.